4.2 First Sends - Timing, Waves, and the 4-Hour Rule

Elite private strategy - not for redistribution

WAR-ROOM NOTES - 4.2 First Sends

THE TWO-WAVE ARGUMENT IS A RISK MODEL, NOT A RITUAL

The dominant risk in any campaign is unvalidated assets. Wave one's job is to validate: does the link resolve, does the audio attach, does the pitch open, does the subject convert? By firing the top 10 first, every failure surface is tested on the warmest converts - the ones most likely to forgive a glitch and least likely to be a loss if a link dies. Wave two then fires with lessons learned. One big send doesn't just risk a broken link to 20 stations; it risks your entire reputation across the market, because a PD who saw a broken payload remembers it.

THE 4-HOUR RULE IS A DIAGNOSTIC, TOO

If a message arrives 9 hours after the PD's local morning, the open rate drops regardless of content - which means you can't attribute a "no open" to your subject line when the real cause was the timestamp. The 4-hour rule keeps your data clean so diagnostic skills work. Timezone discipline isn't courtesy; it's experimental hygiene.

THE FRIDAY 11AM CUTOFF - WHY IT'S A HARD RULE

PDs read Monday-Thursday with intent. Friday reads are skimmed, Saturday/Sunday don't exist, and Monday-morning email is a fresh inbox - not a stale one. A Friday-afternoon miss becomes a Monday-morning burial: six-days-old, three inches down the queue, zero context. Scheduled sends that respect the inbox behave like journalism, not cold outreach.

THE OPEN DIAGNOSTIC TREE (MEMORIZE)

- Low opens, A-tier: subject line -> rewrite engine.
- Low opens, B-tier: sender identity / personalization -> add station-specific layer.
- Opens, zero replies: pitch body -> tighten proof ask, kill the fat.
- Clicks, zero replies: EPK or audio friction -> run the 60-second test again.
- Bounces: contact data -> re-verify before re-send.
- Replies with questions: you're in. Do the 12-minute call (Module 5.1), not another email.

THE CAMPAIGN CLOCK STARTS AT WAVE ONE

Most artists treat "campaign" as one event and "follow-up" as an afterthought. Operators treat the first send as t_minus zero on a 21-day operation: follow-up touches are pre-dated in the war room before wave one fires. If your touch-two and touch-three dates aren't already on the calendar, you haven't started a campaign - you've sent an email.